

# THE BOSS

**His 154th film reinforces Rajnikant's status as a cultural phenomenon, unleashing a colourful, cacophonous, continent-hopping social drama which justifies his tag of being the country's highest paid actor. Moving from dark to fair, cigarettes to mint, crore to more, the former bus conductor from Bangalore proves he is an iconic entertainer.**

**Rs 20 cr**  
is his salary for acting in *Sivaji*

■ By Lakshmi Subramanian

**T**he Rs 20-crore fingers play the piano on the bald skull. Cool, utters M.G. Ravikrishnan, a.k.a. MGR, with a blindingly white smile, towards the end of the noisy kitschy three-hour spectacle that has all of Tamil Nadu (and with 850 screens across 25 countries, even beyond) enthralled for the past two weeks. Rajnikant a.k.a. Sivaji Rao Gaekwad, the neon-lit superstar of Tamil cinema, who is actually a Kannadiga who speaks Marathi, is back on the big screen after two years in *Sivaji: The Boss*, a Rs 78-crore movie that is part comedy and part serious political statement. It is also an ageing star's attempt to retain his agelessness, as he squires a sultry siren half his age across crazily-shifting continents and creative dreamscapes.

No one seems to mind it. It is a movie that had M. Karunanidhi and J. Jayalalithaa show a rare unanimity (interesting movie, both said). It is a phenomenon that has witnessed riots

as far as Malaysia (trouble erupted in Klang's Sri Intan theatre when AVM productions that produced *Sivaji* sent only 42 prints, of the promised 53 to Malaysia. It is a money-making machine that has already soaked up Rs 96 crore for AVM from distributors across India and abroad. And it is a cultural event that will now return only in 2008 when Rajnikant's next film releases, a Rs 20-crore animated movie, directed by his 23-year-old daughter Soundarya, which will have his voice as *Sultan: The Warrior*.

Whether it is his classic dialogues (pigs come in hordes, the lion walks alone, he says to resounding applause in *Sivaji*) or his physical agility (first it was the cigarette flick and later the

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